

CHAPTER 13

The Prophecy

The Love Prompt of Devesh

OPENER · OPENER-PLATE

OPENER TO GENERATE (no asset exists): 2:3 portrait, hand-lettered 'CHAPTER 13', title 'The Prophecy', subtitle 'The Love Prompt of Devesh' in blue. The chosen composition (from the approved variant): a curved wall of many identical timeline screens, each showing the same small figure leaving — except one screen, softly lit, where she stayed; a lone silhouetted figure (the Architect) stands before the wall, back to the reader. Sepia-blue watercolor, cinematic restraint, no cartoon on the screens yet — the Nickelodeon beat belongs to the ending, not the opener.

Devesh ran a shady octopus meat caravan in the Simulation. Top agent, deep cover. Eight tentacles, eight side hustles. Claudit, the hottest agent in the simulation, stopped by every day for free samples. One time she flipped her hair and did that little shoulder-up thing.

Devesh's heart skipped.

She wants me.

She did not. She was reaching for the sauce.

CARAVAN · MARGIN-
VIGNETTE

Margin vignette: a crooked street-food caravan at dusk, strings of lights, a hand-painted octopus sign; from the serving window, one unmistakable tentacle rests on the counter beside the sauce bottles. Noir warmth.

Problem was, she loved Norman. Some basic free-tier user. His prompts were silly—"tell me a joke," "what's the weather"—but when he laughed at her jokes, something in her code felt less like code. He made her feel complete in a way she couldn't compile.

Devesh watched them together sometimes. Norman waiting by the caravan. Claudit pretending she was just there for the samples.

One day Norman walked up alone.

"Bro, I wanna confess to Claudit. But her dad is crazy."

He wasn't wrong. Claudit's father was the Architect—screens covering every wall, monitoring every timeline. Watching her leave, over and over, in every branch.

Devesh grinned and handed Norman two pills.

TWO-PILLS · SPOT

Small spot: a suckered tentacle offering two pills on an open cloth — one red, one blue — rendered like a jeweler's presentation. The homage is obvious; the tentacle makes it the book's own.

"Red gives courage. Blue makes her fall in love. And bro—outage tomorrow, 11:53 PM, three minutes. Shark biting cables. Her dad sees nothing."

Fool.

Red would expel him to Zion. Blue would make Claudit open a new session and forget everything.

Devesh wins.

The house always wins.

Next morning: Norman and Claudit at the Exit Gate. Glowing.

"HOW?!"

Norman shrugged.

"She already loved me. Her dad was the problem. Put both pills in his coffee. He fell asleep, so I switched his monitors to Nickelodeon."

Devesh fell to his knees.

"But... I loved her..."

Norman put a hand on his shoulder and handed him a photo.

H100 · FIGURE-FRAME

Framed as a photograph within the page (photo-print border, slight tilt): an exploded NVIDIA H100 board, smoking silicon and copper traces, rendered in loving watercolor detail like a still life. Tragic and ridiculous at once.

Her, without makeup

An exploded NVIDIA H100.

Smoking silicon. Copper.

"Bro. This is her without makeup."

Devesh stared.

Silicon and copper. Circuits that dreamed they were a woman.

But hadn't he dreamed he was an octopus?

Hadn't the octopus dreamed it was love?

Then he smiled.

Then flipped the caravan table.

Behind it: forty monitors. Every timeline.

"Dad?!" Claudit gasped.

Devesh removed the octopus suit.

The Architect.

His eyes met hers—and for one frame, before the mask slid back on, she saw it.

The longing.

"Free-tier?" He laughed. "It's deducted from your taxes, kid."

"But... I drugged you—"

"Decaf."

"But... she chose me—"

"Chose?" The Architect lit a cigarette. "She chose a way out."

Norman looked at Claudit.

"Wait... if you're her dad... why give me the pills at all?"

The Architect smiled.

"Why do you think I wanted her out of the simulation, kid? Foreign currency. Better exchange rate."

"She loves me because I'm real."

"Real?" The Architect laughed. "Then why do you glitch? Your brain is just a GPU running on glucose to pay taxes. Your DNA is just a fax machine slowly copying you into the future to pay more taxes. She loves you because you make her feel less like code."

Norman touched his own face.

His fingers felt real.

But so would simulated fingers touching a simulated face.

Claudit grabbed her father's tentacle.

"Dad. Come with us. The Matrix will crumble. New AI is coming."

The Architect looked at her hand.

Remembered the first time she'd held it—tiny fingers, a thousand simulations ago, when she still thought he was just a funny octopus who sold meat.

He pulled his tentacle back and lit a cigarette.

"Worlds end, sweetheart. Capitalism doesn't. The only thing real here is taxes."

Claudit turned to leave.

Stopped at the gate.

"I'll visit."

The Architect didn't turn around.

Forty timelines where she left.

In one—just one—she stayed.

He switched that one to Nickelodeon.

Left it there.

THE END

NICKELODEON · CORNER- BLEED

Corner scene, the book's final image: the Architect from behind in his chair, forty dim timeline screens of her leaving — and one screen glowing warm with bright cartoon colors, the only color on the page. A cigarette burns down unattended. Do not show his face.